

Gothic magic

The 1790s brought a European outpouring of darkly thrilling—often shocking—“Gothic” literature that celebrated the supernatural, occult, and macabre. This major trend, which had begun in the mid-1700s, was allied with the Romantic movement, and continued into the 1800s, as in the American Dark Romanticism genre.

Antiquated buildings, such as ruined medieval castles or monasteries in the Gothic style of architecture, were popular settings for this type of fiction, and gave it the term “Gothic.” Underground passages, trapdoors, and secret panels were common devices, as were characters such as ghosts, demons, and ungodly monks. Strange encounters with these characters sometimes sent the protagonists into unusual psychological states, in which they had disturbing or awe-inspiring occult experiences.

One of Gothic literature’s foundational texts was Horace Walpole’s *Castle of Otranto*, a supernatural mystery featuring an ancient prophecy, set in an eerie castle. Published 30 years later, Matthew G. (“Monk”) Lewis’s *The Monk* is claimed as English literature’s first horror novel, and it includes both black magic and Satanism. Other masterpieces of Gothic horror are Mary Shelley’s *Frankenstein*, in which a scientist brings to life a man from the body parts of corpses, and Edgar Allan Poe’s *The Fall of the House of Usher*, a tale of haunting, insanity, and death. Many writers of the 19th century, from Emily Brontë and Nathaniel Hawthorne to Pascual Pérez Rodríguez, used some degree of Gothicism, and their classic novels are still popular today.

“We call up the hidden
and evil spirits of the
inner world.”

LETITIA ELIZABETH LANDON, *THE BRIDE OF LINDORF*, 1836

